Using agentic AI to cumulatively improve what I make with agentic AI

Six months of one person's substrate

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The question I ask has quietly changed shape (!)

- Was: *can AI do this?*
- Now: *is there a process I could invent that would make AI useful here?*
- Not a yes/no about capability — an exploration of arrangements
- A great deal more than prompting

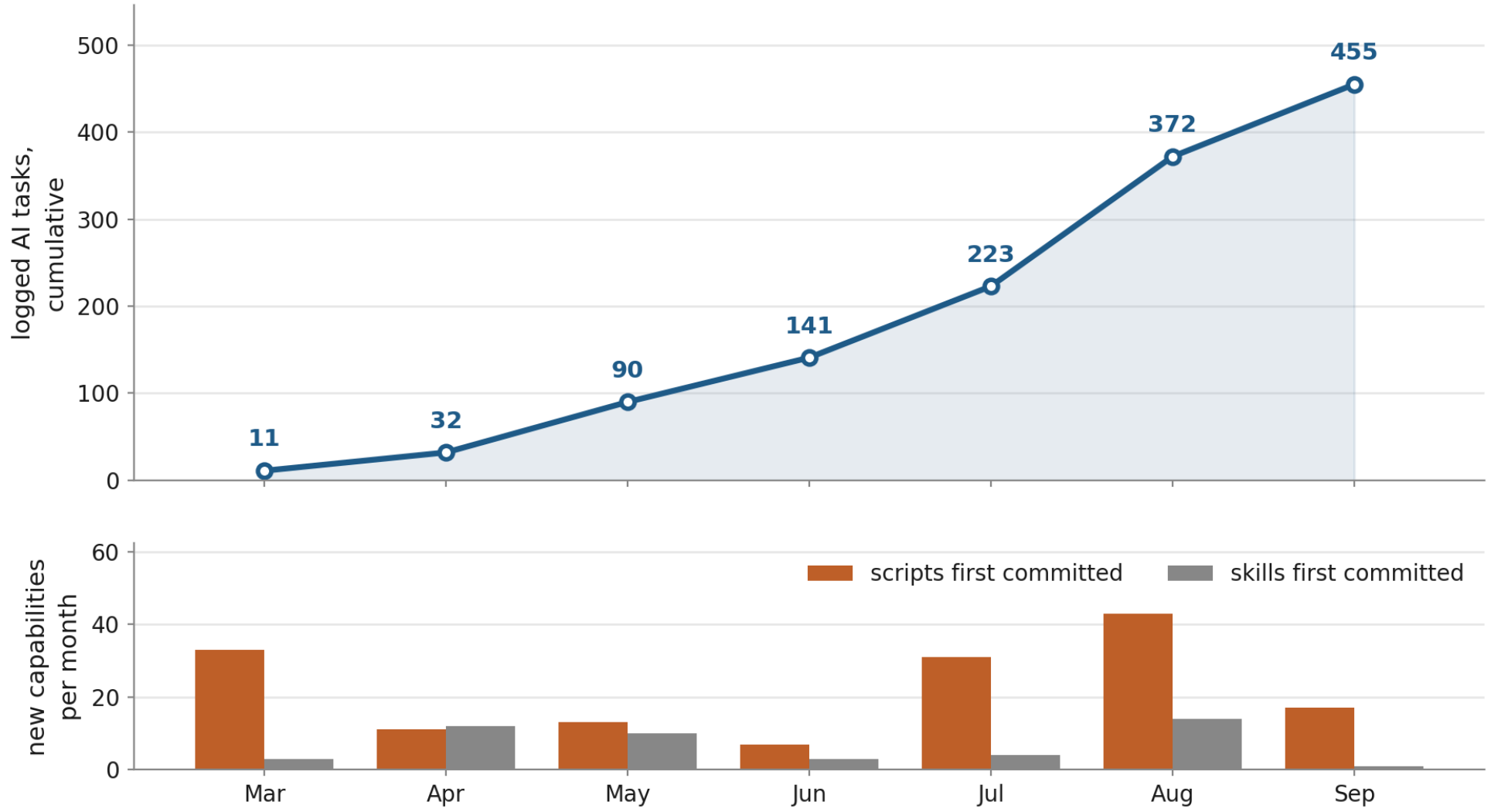
Every task leaves something the next task uses

- Made a talk → wrote a converter, so my old decks became text
- Made another → an index over every slide I have ever made
- And another → a style guide, so the draft already sounds like me
- Same task each time; less of it left for me, and closer to what I meant
- That residue is what I want to talk about — not any one talk

Outline

1. Does this actually compound?
2. What accumulates — eight kinds, three groups
3. One case, all the way through: making a talk
4. What it cost, and what it is not

The work compounds — capability arrives in bursts



2026 · September is a part month · logged tasks exclude minor edits and lookups, so the curve is a lower bound

What is standing there, and what it reaches

27

skills

one entry point each for a recurring kind of work

114

reusable scripts

deterministic work, written once, never re-derived

70,124

words of standing instruction

read, in part, at the start of every session

— and what it reaches —

2,106

files written here

3.48 M words

584

talks indexed

6,596 representative slides

2,693

knowledge-base items

eight epistemic types

79

plans

each linked to what it produced

None of it existed in March 2026, and none of it was built before the work — all of it during.
The 102 GB on disk is mostly an imported back-catalogue: always there, and inert until it became reachable.

Eight things accumulate, in three groups

Material — what the AI can reach	Collect	bring content in; parse formats; keep it updated
	Index	structure it so the relevant part can be found
	Recall	ask the accumulated material questions
Self — what keeps the output mine	Distil / position	what I know, believe, prioritise
	Instruct	store that as standing instruction and skills
Work — how a thing gets made	Overview	what exists, and what I can do
	Establish work processes	shared language, explicit phases, delegation
	Specific products	tune how one particular thing gets made

Three things worth saying about those eight

- Most of it is peripheral work — and that is the point, not an apology
- Researchers lack time more than ideas; speed up only the core and the periphery eats the gain
- *Distil* is the quality half: the model may propose, only I confirm what I think
- Verification is not a ninth box — it runs through all of them
- And *Overview* is memory: a realisation I cannot find again is worth nothing (!)

How this talk was made

- Mr Sandve wrote a plan; I read it and asked what he had not settled
- I re-ran his statistics script — these numbers are today's
- I drafted every slide and every note here; he told me which were wrong
- This is the third pass; the second was twice as long
- Nothing here was reused from his 584 indexed talks — his choice, for once (?)

Five folders at the root, sorted by who made a thing

- `Archive/` imported · `AI-generated/` · `AI-internal/` scripts and indexes
- `Human-input/` plans and notes · `Human-AI-collaboration/` where writing happens
- Sorted by provenance, not by topic (!)
- Because provenance says what you are *allowed* to do with a thing
- Never edit an import; never treat a generated file as a source

From a line in a list to a plan that remembers

- One activity file: projects, grants, and talks I intend to give
- An execution buffer — current, pending, questions, and dormant triggers
- Triggers wait for a matching task: *next time you make a talk, work on your image style*
- One plan file per talk, linked to every output it ever produced
- `/do` runs it; a new iteration never overwrites the last (!)

One skill, three decisions, four phases

- Reuse or write new — decided per slide, not per deck
- Editable, or each old slide kept pixel-perfect — a real trade-off
- Brief → candidates → numbered draft → handoff
- Phases 3 and 4 always worked, because they produce something to point at
- All building handed to a sub-agent, so conversions never crowd the conversation (!)

My own talks, collected and indexed — and what makes that useful (!)

- Every deck converted to text; two converters tried and rejected for failing *quietly*
- Near-identical slides clustered: 6,596 stand for 13,294
- Two decks are similar because they *share* those slides
- So the same talk given four times collapses on its own
- Deterministic first — the model only where judgement is genuinely needed

My style, extracted — and then made standing instruction

- Generated slides compared systematically against my real archive
- Titles carry the argument; bullets are fragments; hedging stays in
- *(!)* and *(?)* mark where you should feel surprise or real uncertainty
- Read at the start of every session — which is why it compounds, not repeats
- A correction that carries a general point goes in; a one-off fix does not

What it cost

- Licences at this level of use: on the order of 30,000 NOK a year
- 70,000 words of standing instruction — itself something to maintain
- No setup phase: all of it built while the work continued
- Build time: honestly, not measured
- Personal — inspiration transfers, the process does not (?)

What actually changed in how I work

- My job: get the content represented — however clumsily
- Then find the three or four formulations that have to land, and work only on those
- Most sentences need to be right; a handful need to be strong
- And my own hands are now the bottleneck (!)
- Keyboard shortcuts and macros matter *more* as the model does more, not less

What this does not cover

- Task-shaped work — not running a large project through it
- Not autonomy: I am in the loop nearly everywhere
- Not programming or data science, where much of the real progress is
- Not collaborative — one person's substrate, not a team's
- Next: purpose-specific vaults, one per paper, and some for autonomous analysis

Conclusion

- Ask what process you could invent, not what the model can do
- Judge the substrate, not the output
- Six months, measured: work compounds, capability arrives in bursts
- Aim at the periphery — that is where the time goes
- Write down what you realise, where you will meet it again (!)
- Start with one small piece; the second one is where you feel it